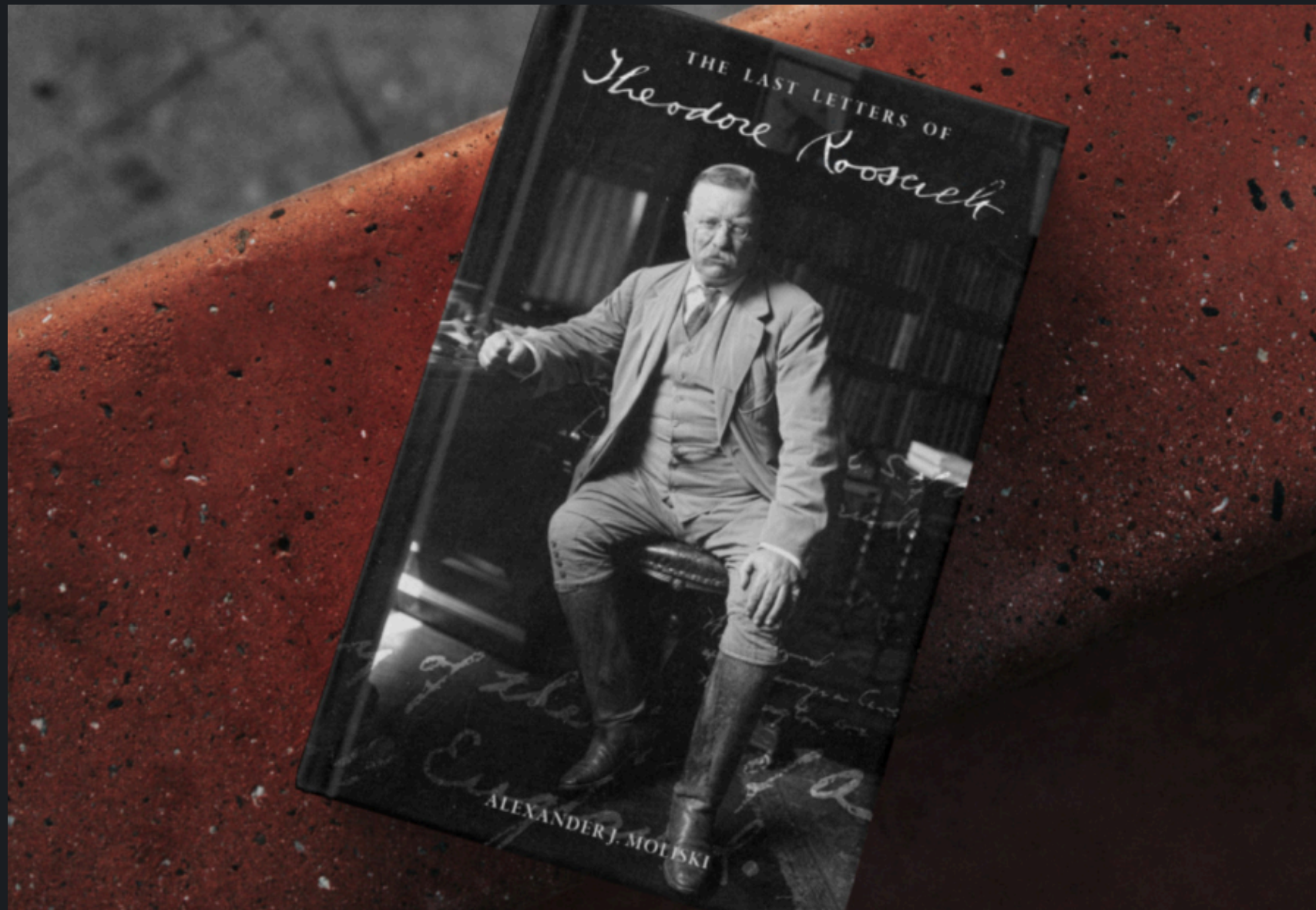


NONFICTION · WRITTEN & RESEARCHED

The Last Letters of Theodore Roosevelt



A full-length book I wrote: ten thousand personal letters, transcribed and researched a century after his death.

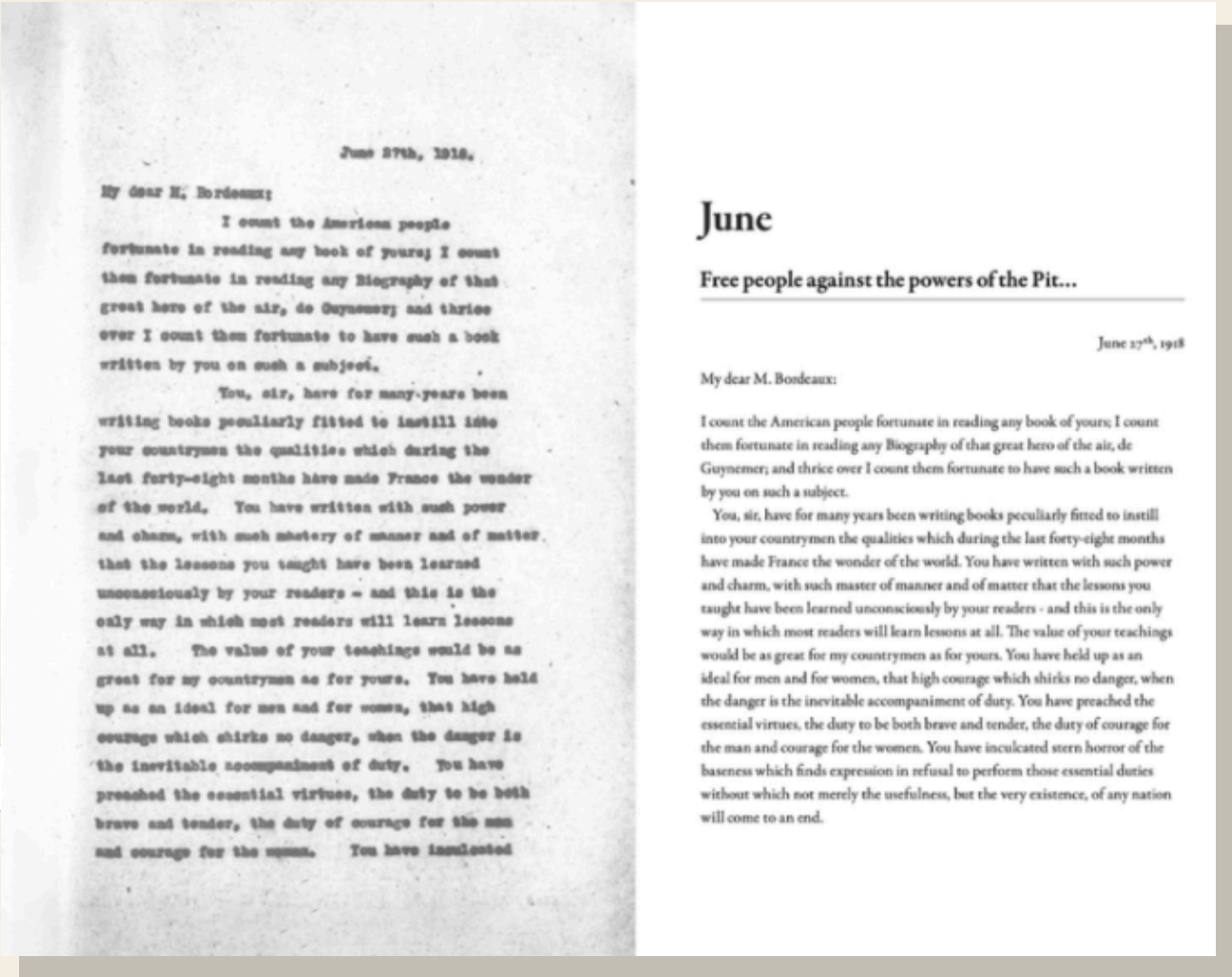
2019 - 2023 · A BOOK BY ALEXANDER J. MOLISKI

Ten thousand letters, a century later

In January 2019 - exactly 100 years after Theodore Roosevelt's death - the Library of Congress released the largest presidential archive ever made public: 300,000 letters, speeches, and musings, available overnight.

Already fascinated by Roosevelt, I started reading, and didn't stop - working through more than 10,000 letters and transcribing my favorites into a full-length book.

- Archival research
- Transcription
- Historical nonfiction
- Original writing



THE RESEARCH

Roosevelt's world, one correspondent at a time

Reading the letters, I found Theodore casually writing to barons of Japan, lords of England, world-famous biologists, explorers, and writers.

So I researched the recipient of each letter and wrote about them - turning a stack of correspondence into a vivid, guided window on the early 1900s.



The Aristocrat Out West

With his neatly-tapered outfit, artfully-designed pistol, and his cleanly-shaved, bespectacled, boy-ish face, Theodore didn't fit in and he was painfully aware of that fact. The men in the Dakotas were true cowboys and he was nothing but a yuppie from the streets of New York. His Harvard degree, healthy inheritance, and high-ranking connections all meant nothing on prairies of the northern badlands. Tales spread quickly in the small western towns, and he knew he had to make a lasting impression, one that would show he was more than what meets the eye.

He was riding through Montana, exploring the sights and scenes of the west on horseback. He was a decent rider and a decent hunter, but had little experience wrangling and wrangling cattle. This small setback didn't stop him from purchasing a ranch and a few hundred head of steer. He was settled on the idea of being a ranchman, and had the capital to make it happen. It was getting late, so he stopped in a hotel for the night. He wasn't much of a drinker, but he was curious to get an idea of the locals, so he headed to the bar. Theodore opened the barroom doors only to find a scene unfolding in front of him: a drunken cowboy strutting up and down the expanse of the bar with revolvers in each hand, a room full of frightened patrons, and several smoking bullet holes in the face of a clock behind the bar.

Roosevelt wasn't the only one taking in the events. As soon as he came through the door the trigger-happy drunk focused on Roosevelt's glasses and called him "four-eyes". Ignoring the man, Roosevelt took a seat and curiously watched for the gunman's next move. Theodore was known to have a sense of style, even in the Badlands he dressed foppishly, had an engraved pistol, and wore circular glasses

Portraits, letters & essays

Each chapter pairs archival photography with the original letters - transcribed by hand - and an essay I wrote putting Roosevelt's world in context.



In Xanadu...

The former president of the United States, now 55-years old, lay sweating and feverish on the bank of an uncharted river in the middle of the Brazilian rain-forest. Roosevelt's fever drove him to delirium, making it impossible for him to walk any further. The party had made a pact to leave behind anyone that jeopardized the lives of others, however none of the men could justify leaving the Colonel behind to die alone in the jungle. The stronger men took turns carrying him through the thick vegetation, along with the canoes and what food they had left. Roosevelt, lost in the fever, recited the same lines of poetry for hours straight, "In Xanadu did Kubla Khan a stately pleasure dome decree."

The expedition of the dark, unknown waters of the Rio da Divida (River of Doubt) was an adventure more difficult and more life-sucking than any Roosevelt had ever faced. If being the president of the most powerful country in the world and dealing with constant stress of that position for eight years aged him, it was nothing compared to what the 615 miles of river did to his body. A group of men, including one of Brazil's most accomplished explorers, Cândido Rondon, fought through some of the most inhospitable environments on the planet. And it showed. After only sixty days, Roosevelt had lost over fifty pounds and was dying of a fever caused by an infection festering on a wound on his leg.

Theodore always had an affinity towards nature and adventure. As a child, he was hardly ever found without an adventure book in front of him. He held high offices, established a family, wrote several best-sellers, and led an army, but his insatiable appetite for adventure was never satisfied. His life was in desperate need

Prologue

On a warm May morning in 1908, three years into Roosevelt's second term, he awoke to the smell of his favorite breakfast—fatty bacon, eggs, and coffee. He and Edith (the first lady) took some time away from the busy chaos of Washington to enjoy a few quiet days in Pine Knot, their summer cottage in Virginia. Theodore worked as hard as anyone in Washington but was known to disappear from time to time. Assistants would later find that he went to the Adirondacks to hunt, or to Yellowstone, or sometimes to his cabin in Virginia. Hiking, hunting, rowing, simple living, and above all, nature, were sources of energy for the president. Throughout his life, he snuck away when things got out of control, and found solace in the solitude of the countryside. After his one, and only, cup of coffee (Edith enacted a strong one-cup-per-day edict long ago in attempts to curb the president's caffeine intake) Roosevelt waited for a knock on the cottage door.

He had no grand plans scheduled for the day, no fabulous bison or bear hunts, no mountain scalings, no, Theodore had a different idea of how to spend the perfect spring day. One of Theodore's most cherished correspondents, John Burroughs (Theodore addresses him affectionately as "Oom John" in letters), a renown American naturalist, and expert birdwatcher, had raised suspicions over one of the president's claims. In a letter, Theodore explained how he was certain he saw a flock of passenger pigeons near his Virginia getaway. This, Burroughs concluded, was too much to be true. Wild passenger pigeons hadn't been seen in the area in over twenty-five years. In fact, the last known living bird died just five years later, rendering the animal extinct. He, of course, had to come and see for himself.

Chapter essays, archival photography, and original transcribed letters

AN EXCERPT

"Sixty-nine state legislatures sat silently waiting for the echoes of accusation to suffocate in the chamber. The youngest member ever elected stood alone in a vast room full of wooden benches, high ceilings, and men in black coats..."

- from The Last Letters of Theodore Roosevelt



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